

The Computer Said No: What You Can Do

Sometimes a government agency uses a computer system to help decide:

- benefits
- housing
- healthcare access
- disability status
- immigration processing
- unemployment
- public assistance
- other important decisions

If you received a letter that says something like:

“Based on available information, you are not eligible.”

you still have rights.

The government cannot simply say:

“The computer decided.”

and end the conversation.

Step 1 — Ask What Rule Was Used

You can ask:

- What rule or policy was used to deny me?
- Was the rule changed recently?
- What information mattered most?
- Was this decision reviewed by a person?

You do not need to understand computers to ask these questions.

Step 2 — Ask How the Decision Was Made

A denial letter is not the whole story.

The agency should be able to explain:

- what information it used
- what system or rules it applied
- how the system reached the result
- whether the system followed its own rules

If the agency cannot explain that, the problem may not be your application.

The problem may be the process.

Step 3 — Ask Two Separate Questions

There are really two different kinds of problems.

Question One:

Did the computer actually follow its own rules?

Maybe:

- the wrong information was used
- the system applied the wrong version of a policy
- the data was incorrect
- the system made a mistake

This is about whether the process worked correctly.

Question Two:

Were the rules themselves fair or lawful?

Maybe:

- the policy itself is unreasonable
- the threshold is unfair
- the system treats people differently
- the explanation makes no sense

This is about whether the rules should be used at all.

Both questions matter.

Step 4 — Ask for Human Review

You can ask for:

- human review
- a hearing
- a written explanation
- the records used in the decision
- the reasons for the denial

If the agency delays review for months or years, that matters too.

A delay that effectively blocks review can become part of the due process problem.

Step 5 — Keep Records

Save:

- denial letters
- emails
- screenshots
- upload confirmations
- appeal forms
- dates and times
- names of agency staff

Write down what happened while it is fresh.

Important Principle

The government is allowed to use computers.

But when the government uses computers to make important decisions about your life, the government still has to explain itself.

A computer system does not remove your right to:

- notice
- explanation
- appeal
- meaningful review

The Core Idea in Plain Language

- No explanation means no meaningful review.
- No review means no real due process.
- A computer decision still has to be understandable enough to challenge.
- If the government acts quickly with computers, it cannot slow down your ability to question the result.

If You Need Help

You may want to contact:

- legal aid organizations
- disability rights groups
- public defenders
- benefits advocates
- immigration advocates
- civil rights organizations
- state ombuds offices

Bring your denial letters and records with you.

Final Principle

The government does not get to avoid accountability by saying:

“The computer made the decision.”

People still have rights.

Those rights do not disappear at machine speed.